Zverev Reaches the Top of Men's Tennis

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Alexander Zverev will replace Jannik Sinner as the men's world number one at his earliest opportunity after reaching the **quarter-finals** in Vienna. Already guaranteed to finish 2026 as the ATP's leading player, he made sure he will rise to the summit on Monday by beating Tallon Griekspoor 6-4 7-5 at the Erste Bank Open.

Zverev, 29, is the 30th man to become ATP world number one, and the second German to reach the **pinnacle** of the men's tour after Boris Becker in 1991. The achievement reflects his body of work this year, having won two **Grand Slam** titles and 64 of his 80 matches. He said it had been a wait, but sometimes you have to wait for the best things in life.

At the start of the year it seemed unthinkable that anybody other than Sinner or Carlos Alcaraz would become world number one. But injuries kept the **dominant** duo out for large chunks of the season, opening the door for Zverev's French Open and US Open titles.

Going into 2026, Alcaraz led the **rankings** with 12,050 points, closely followed by Sinner on 11,500, while third-ranked Zverev had 5,110 points. The pair had split all eight **Grand Slam** titles in 2024 and 2025 between them. He did not face a top-10 player until beating Ben Shelton in the New York final.

As the season entered its final stretch, Zverev secured the year-end number one ranking when Alcaraz lost in Shanghai on 12 October. Beating Griekspoor made him the first man other than Sinner and Alcaraz to top the **rankings** since Novak Djokovic in June 2024. Zverev conceded he would maybe not be the world's best player if both his rivals were healthy and at the top of their game, but he has efficiently beaten what has been in front of him, in the greatest season of his career. Next he faces British number one Arthur Fery in the **quarter-finals**.

Word Treasure

quarter-finals -- The round of a tournament with eight players left, played just before the semi-finals.

pinnacle -- The very highest point that someone can reach.

Grand Slam -- One of the four biggest tennis tournaments of the year.

rankings -- A list that orders players by how well they have done, with the best at the top.

dominant -- Much stronger or more successful than the others around you.

Background you need

In men's tennis, the world number one ranking goes to the player with the best results over the season, and it can change hands when one player overtakes another.

The four Grand Slam tournaments are the biggest events in tennis, and winning them brings the most ranking points and prestige.

Injuries can keep even the best players out for long stretches, which can open the door for another player to climb to the top.

In such a season, the two players who began the year on top missed large parts of it, while another player kept winning.

Break it down

LEAD: Alexander Zverev will replace Jannik Sinner as men's world number one on Monday.

KEY EVENT: Zverev beat Tallon Griekspoor 6-4 7-5 at the Erste Bank Open in Vienna to reach the quarter-finals.

+- WHO: Alexander Zverev, 29, the 30th man to become ATP world number one and the second German after Boris Becker.

+- RECORD: Two Grand Slam titles and 64 wins from 80 matches this year.

+- CONTEXT: He was already guaranteed to finish 2026 as the ATP's leading player.

BACKGROUND: At the start of the year Sinner or Carlos Alcaraz seemed certain to be number one, but injuries kept them out for large parts of the season.

EVIDENCE: Going into 2026, Alcaraz led with 12,050 points and Sinner had 11,500, while Zverev had 5,110; Zverev secured year-end number one when Alcaraz lost in Shanghai on 12 October.

OPEN QUESTION: Would Zverev be the world's best player if both his rivals were healthy and at the top of their game? He conceded he maybe would not be.

Why it matters

The top ranking is the sport's clearest measure of a season's best player, and Zverev's rise shows how injuries at the top can reshape a whole season -- and how seizing that opening still takes a career-best year.

Test what you remember

1. Who will Zverev replace as men's world number one?

(A) Jannik Sinner
(B) Arthur Fery
(C) Novak Djokovic
(D) Carlos Alcaraz

2. How did Zverev make sure he would rise to number one on Monday?

(A) By winning the Shanghai tournament
(B) By beating Tallon Griekspoor 6-4 7-5 in Vienna
(C) By withdrawing from the Erste Bank Open
(D) By beating Ben Shelton in Paris

3. How many Grand Slam titles has Zverev won this year, according to the article?

(A) Eight
(B) Two
(C) One
(D) Four

4. Going into 2026, who led the rankings?

(A) Alexander Zverev, with 5,110 points
(B) Carlos Alcaraz, with 12,050 points
(C) Novak Djokovic
(D) Jannik Sinner, with 11,500 points

5. When did Zverev secure the year-end number one ranking?

(A) When Sinner lost in Vienna
(B) When he beat Ben Shelton in New York
(C) In June 2024
(D) When Alcaraz lost in Shanghai on 12 October

6. Who does Zverev face next in the quarter-finals?

(A) Boris Becker
(B) Novak Djokovic
(C) British number one Arthur Fery
(D) Tallon Griekspoor

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: B 3: B 4: B 5: D 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Alexander Zverev: He said it had been a wait, but sometimes you have to wait for the best things in life, and he conceded he would maybe not be the world's best player if both his rivals were healthy and at the top of their game.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):